colonial state and the British-American capitalistic splitters and warmongers to be answered by a government of the people.’27

In a brief address, Wilhelm Pieck proclaimed the German Democratic Republic on 7 October 1949, with an appeal to all Germans to fight against ‘NATO warmongers,’ and ‘German traitors in the service of American imperialism.’ The founding manifesto demanded West Germany be abolished, occupation troops withdraw, the creation of a unified German currency, the prohibition of foreign investment (unless approved by Germans) and increased trade with the Soviet Union. Watching events unfold from over the border, the British, French and US High Commissioners for Germany, denounced the SED as having no title to represent Eastern Germany with the ‘artificial creation of a popular assembly’ which possessed no mandate for this purpose. Leaders in the ‘so-called’ German Democratic Republic, they charged, ‘were not freely’ chosen but instruments of Soviet foreign policy.

On paper, the first GDR constitution looked remarkably progressive, guaranteeing basic political rights and demands of the labour movement. In the first section, state authority was defined with ‘Article 19’ stating that economic order must ‘correspond to the principles of social justice’. Although private initiative was desired (Articles 21 to 23), private ownership could be nationalised without compensation (Article 24). Furthermore, natural resources were declared ‘public property’ (Article 25). More ominously, provisions prohibiting strikes and walk-outs opened the possibility of repression under criminal law (Article 6). A few days later, when Pieck was elected president, Honecker sent 30,000 FDJ teens to march in procession along Unter den Linden. Honecker remembered:

Torches were alight as far as one could see. After the World Youth Song had been sung, Berlin’s Mayor Friedrich Ebert opened the demonstration. As FDJ chairman, I was given the floor to present to Wilhelm Pieck the oath of the German youth. It ended with the vow: ‘We, the German youth, swear loyalty to the GDR, because it wants to and will bring peace